

Exemplar: Draft a Data Retention Policy for an Oil Exploration Company

This document presents an exemplar solution to the lab, 'Draft a Data Retention Policy for an Oil Exploration Company'. Please remember that this is just one point of view and not a definitive solution.

Solution

Task 1: Understand the scope and objectives

Step 1: Identify the types of data managed by the organization.

Types of data managed by the organization
Seismic data
Drilling reports
Financial records
Employee records

Step 2: Define the policy objectives.

Policy objectives
Ensure regulatory compliance
Optimize data storage costs
Safeguard sensitive and critical data
Support operational continuity

Task 2: Review applicable regulations

Step 1: Research and document all the applicable regulatory requirements for environment, finance, health and safety, and global standards.

Sectors	Applicable regulatory requirement
Environmental	EPA regulations may dictate how long exploration-related records are retained
Financial	SOX compliance for financial data retention
Health and safety	OSHA for employee safety data.

Global standards	GDPR (for European operations), CCPA (for California operations), etc.
------------------	---

Task 3: Conduct stakeholder consultations

Step 1: Engage with key stakeholders of the IT and data management, legal and compliance, and business unit teams.

Key stakeholders	Purpose of the consultation
IT and data management teams	To understand system capabilities and storage limits
Legal and compliance teams	For input on legal and regulatory obligations
Business units	To capture operational requirements for historical data

Task 4: Categorize data

Step 1: Classify data into the following categories: critical operational data, compliance data, support data, and archived data.

Categories	Data
Critical operational data	• Seismic • Well logs • Reservoir data
Compliance data	• Environmental • Financial • HSE records
Support data	• Emails • Internal memos • Training records
Archived data	• Legacy systems • Historical exploration records

Task 5: Define retention periods

Step 1: Establish retention periods for the following categories: regulatory requirements, operational needs, and business records.

Categories	Retention periods
Regulatory requirements	Retain seismic and drilling data for 7-10 years based on industry norms

Operational needs	Retain reservoir models for at least 20 years for future reuse
Business records	Retain financial and contract records for 6-7 years (or longer, if necessary)

Task 6: Outline policy structure

Step 1: Draft a clear and structured policy document, including the purpose and scope, definitions, roles and responsibilities, retention schedule, data archiving and deletion, and policy review and updates.

Policy requirements	Objectives
Purpose and scope	Explain why the policy exists and what data it covers
Definitions	Clarify terms like "retention period," "data archiving," and "data destruction"
Roles and responsibilities	Data Stewards: Monitor compliance with retention schedules IT Teams: Ensure secure storage and timely deletion Legal Teams: Approve retention timelines
Retention schedule	Include table mapping data categories to retention periods
Data archiving and deletion	Outline procedures for archiving and securely deleting data

An example of a retention schedule

Data category	Retention period	Retention reason	Format
Seismic Data	20 years	Operational reuse	Digital
Employee Health Records	7 years	OSHA compliance	Physical
Financial Records	6 years	SOX compliance	Digital

Data category	Retention period	Retention reason	Format
Exploration Reports	10 years	Regulatory and operational purposes	Digital
Training Records	3 years	Business requirement	Digital

Note: By identifying the types of data and the applicable regulatory requirements, you can develop a data retention policy to manage enterprise data assets effectively. A structured approach can help you determine how long data must be stored, in what format, and how it must be securely destroyed to save the organization from unnecessary data hoarding.